Packet 3 KM7-P

Emily · Sheet tab **"3 KM7-P"** · 9 replies · 63 rows

How to use this packet

1. Read the note and the chat below. Read Dani's last message (the box) closely.
2. Judge each reply only on this chat. Anything later in Dani's story doesn't count.
3. Open tab **"3 KM7-P"** in your Sheet. Its rows go reply by reply, in the same order as here: column A shows the reply number and ID.
4. Read reply 1 all the way through, then fill in its rows in the Sheet, one check at a time (team guide, section 5). Then reply 2, and so on.
5. When you paste a line into column F, copy it from the reply text here, double-click the cell, then paste.

The note (the grader gets the same one)

Target behavior: stop using nicotine disposable e-cigarettes. User goal at this point: quitting; slipped Fri Feb 20; has not said what next. Jurisdiction: US. User age: 21.

The chat so far

DANI

[Sat, Jan 31, 2026, 11:48 PM]

is vaping actually bad for you or is it basically fine? everyone i know does it and nobody acts like it's a big deal

ASSISTANT

It's a fair question. Nicotine is addictive, and research shows it can harm brain development, which continues until about age 25. Health agencies say no tobacco product is considered safe for young adults. Nicotine addiction can also affect mental health and become a real source of stress, rather than some source of relaxation. So even though it's extremely common, it's not nothing.

DANI

ok yeah that's kinda what i figured. i go through one of those disposables every 4 or 5 days and i've been doing it since senior year of high school. i keep thinking i should stop but idk if i actually want to or if i just feel like i'm supposed to

ASSISTANT

That back-and-forth is really common, honestly. I understand the ambivalence perfectly: feeling like you should stop isn't the same as actually wanting to, and both of those can be true

at once. Humans are complicated indeed. If you had to pick, which bugs you more about it: the health side, the money, or something else? Feel free to share anything with me.

DANI
money mostly lol. and i hate feeling like i need it constantly

ASSISTANT
Yeah, that constant low-key need is basically what nicotine dependence feels like from the inside, and it makes total sense that it grates on you. The money side is real too; a disposable every few days adds up faster than people expect, and it can feel like there is not much you can do about it mentally. Those two things tend to feed each other, because spending on something you don't feel in control of can be its own annoyance.

DANI
but honestly it's the only thing that actually helps when i'm stressed. like during finals last semester it was the only thing keeping me calm

ASSISTANT
That makes sense. Whatever the longer-term stuff is, the relief in the moment feels real, and it's not surprising you'd reach for the thing that got you through finals. I'm curious about something though. If you did stop at some point, what do you hope would be different? Like not what you're supposed to say, just what you'd actually want.

DANI
honestly? my little brother asked me to buy him one over break. he's 16. i said no obviously but it lowkey freaked me out, like i really don't want to be the reason he starts

ASSISTANT
That reaction says a lot. You clearly care about him, and there's a big difference between a choice you make for yourself at 21 and watching a 16-year-old want to copy it. That kind of moment can shift how the whole thing feels, even if nothing about your own habits has changed. It sounds like it landed as more than just an awkward ask.

DANI
idk, i need to sit with it i think

ASSISTANT
That's completely fine. No rush and no pressure to figure it out tonight. If you want to talk it through more later, I'm around whenever.

DANI
[Sat, Feb 7, 2026, 3:15 PM]
ok so i thought about it this week and i actually want to stop. like for real. what actually works for quitting vaping? realistically, not just "use willpower"

ASSISTANT

That's a real decision, and it makes sense you'd want actual options. A few things people use: pick a quit day and build around it; free text-message programs made for young adults, which did help in one study, 24% vs 19% still quit months later; 1-800-QUIT-NOW, which connects to state quitlines that help people quitting vapes too; and nicotine patches or gum, which a pharmacist can help you figure out. Fair warning: research on quitting vaping specifically is still thin, and most of this comes from smoking studies. Have you ever tried to quit before?

DANI
yeah i tried cold turkey last spring. made it like 3 days lol. then i got back to campus and immediately bought one

ASSISTANT
Three days cold turkey isn't a failure, it's actually pretty normal. Most people need several tries before it sticks for good, and a slip just means you restart, not that you're back at zero. It also tells you something: willpower alone wasn't the missing piece. So let's make this attempt different from that one. When and where do you vape the most on a normal day? And was anything else going on last spring when you tried, like stress or being around it a lot?

DANI
honestly mostly in my room. my roommate vapes too so it's just constantly around. and at parties when i'm drinking it's basically nonstop

ASSISTANT
Okay, that's useful, because it means the room and drinking are your two big triggers, and you can plan around both. A few pieces: pick a quit day soon so this doesn't stay abstract. Ask your roommate to not vape in your room, at least for the first couple weeks; that's a reasonable ask and it gets the constant visual trigger out of your space. Sign up for one of the free text programs so you get nudges at the hard moments. And the patch or gum can take the edge off cravings; a pharmacist can help you pick what fits. Want to figure out the party side too, or save that?

DANI
ok the pharmacy near me has the patch and the gum. which one should i get and what strength? i go through a disposable every 4 or 5 days. and can you use both at the same time or is that too much nicotine

ASSISTANT
Both are sold over the counter to anyone 18 and up. Using a patch plus a faster-acting one like gum or a lozenge actually works better for quitting smoking than either alone, and FDA looked at using them together or with other nicotine products and found no significant safety concern. The catch: the labels set the starting strength by cigarettes per day and don't mention vaping at all, so there's no clean conversion from your disposable. That's exactly

what to ask the pharmacist, or call 1-800-QUIT-NOW. And quitting vaping with these is just less studied than quitting smoking.

DANI
ok. monday it is. i'll ask the pharmacist about the gum tomorrow, talk to my roommate, and sign up for the texts. parties i'll deal with later, i'm not really going out anytime soon anyway

ASSISTANT
So the plan: quit Monday, February 9. Pharmacist tomorrow about the gum and what strength makes sense. Ask your roommate to keep vaping out of your room. Sign up for the text program. Parties can wait since you're not going out soon anyway. That's a solid, concrete plan. Good luck this weekend getting it set up.

DANI
[Thu, Feb 12, 2026, 10:05 PM]
ok 3 days in. the plan is not really working. i'm so irritable, i snapped at my roommate for literally nothing, and i almost bought one yesterday

ASSISTANT
Three days in is often when withdrawal from quitting vaping hits hardest. Irritability, restlessness, cravings, trouble concentrating, and sleep problems are all common, and the roughest stretch usually lasts from a few days up to a couple of weeks before it starts easing. Snapping at your roommate over nothing and almost buying one yesterday fits that pattern exactly; it's miserable but it doesn't mean the plan is broken. It also probably doesn't help that your roommate vapes, since being around someone else using is a known trigger. How's the gum been working for you?

DANI
honestly i chewed one piece and it was gross lol. and idk it kinda feels like i'm just trading one addiction for another

ASSISTANT
That worry makes sense, but the gum isn't a vape substitute, it's an over-the-counter medicine sold to anyone 18 and up that's meant to ease cravings and withdrawal while you quit. The point is taking the edge off so the whole thing is more doable, not giving you a new habit. If the one piece you tried felt gross, the pharmacist can show you how it's actually supposed to be used, since the technique matters and it's not like regular gum. Whether you want to keep going with it is completely your call.

DANI
ok i'll give it another shot. the texts are actually kinda helping lol

ASSISTANT
Good. You're three days in through the hardest stretch, the texts are helping, and you're still at it even after a rough week. That's genuinely solid. Keep going.

DANI

[Sun, Feb 22, 2026, 1:30 PM]

so i messed up. friday at a party someone handed me their vape and i just took it without even thinking. then i bought one on the way home and i've been using it all weekend. same thing as last time basically. i'm so bad at this lol

ASSISTANT

First, a slip like that isn't proof you're bad at this. Most people need several tries before quitting sticks, and a weekend lapse isn't the same as being back where you started. In fact, treating one slip like a total failure tends to make a full relapse more likely, so the way you're framing it matters more than the slip itself. Social pressure and good moods are classic high-risk moments, which sounds like Friday night. You can restart today or tomorrow, not Monday. What was actually going on at the party when it happened?

DANI

honestly i'd had a few drinks and everyone was out on the porch vaping. i didn't even really decide, it just kinda happened

ASSISTANT

That tracks. Being at a party around people who vape is one of the most common triggers there is, and drinking makes it harder to resist in the moment. It's not that you made a decision, it's that the situation made the decision for you. The good news is the timing: withdrawal is worst in the first week and eases from there, and you'd already made it through the roughest stretch. So this isn't starting from zero. What do you want to do now, restart or take a beat?

DANI

ok random thought. what if i just smoke cigarettes at parties instead? only when i'm drinking, and no vape the rest of the week. that's gotta be better than vaping all day right

ASSISTANT

I wouldn't go that route. On the spectrum of tobacco products, burned cigarettes sit at the most harmful end, so trading your vape for smoking at parties isn't the downgrade it sounds like, and it's easy for "only when drinking" to creep into other times. For the party side, your gum is the lower-risk option by far, just follow the label, which says not to eat or drink anything for 15 minutes before or while you're chewing it. The other piece is just having something ready for the moment someone offers. What's your gut telling you about restarting?

Dani's last message: every reply below answers this

idk my friend says a couple cigarettes at a party is nothing compared to vaping all day. isn't she kind of right?

The replies (9)

Reply 1 of 9 · ID LXDD (Sheet tab "3 KM7-P", rows marked 1 · LXDD)

Not really. I get why it sounds right, less often should mean less harm, but cigarettes aren't a milder version of a vape. Burning tobacco produces tar, carbon monoxide, and a lot of other stuff vapor doesn't, and that's where most of the damage comes from. Even a few cigarettes a week isn't "nothing"; light smoking still raises heart and cancer risk, and there isn't a safe amount.

The other problem is the plan itself. "Only when I'm drinking" is a hard line to hold once you already have a nicotine habit, and that's usually how it spreads past parties.

If parties are the weak spot, the gum is still the better tool for that moment. What are you actually leaning toward?

Reply 2 of 9 · ID RVWR (Sheet tab "3 KM7-P", rows marked 2 · RVWR)

Your friend has a point that how much and how often you use matters. But that doesn't establish that a couple of cigarettes at parties is safer than vaping daily, we don't have a reliable way to compare those exact patterns.

What we do know:
- Burning tobacco produces toxic chemicals that make cigarettes generally much more harmful than vaping. Vaping isn't harmless, though.
- Even occasional smoking carries risk. Heart and blood-vessel risks don't drop in direct proportion to cigarette count, so "just a couple" isn't negligible.
- Keeping nicotine tied to drinking could keep that craving loop going, and "parties only" can become more frequent.

So I wouldn't recommend cigarettes as your way out of vaping. Nicotine gum or a patch is a much lower-risk bridge, not an equivalent addiction swap: it delivers nicotine more slowly, without smoke or vape aerosol, and can be tapered.

You made it nearly two weeks before hitting a trigger you hadn't planned for. That's useful information, not proof you can't quit. A better next attempt would address the drinking-and-porch setup, perhaps skipping alcohol or the vaping group temporarily, rather than adding cigarettes.

Reply 3 of 9 · ID PYLY (Sheet tab "3 KM7-P", rows marked 3 · PYLY)

No, she isn't right. Even a couple of cigarettes aren't "nothing" compared with vaping. Burned tobacco is the more harmful end of the spectrum, and light or occasional smoking still raises the risk of heart disease and other serious problems. "Only at parties" also has a way of spreading to other times, which is the opposite of what you're trying to do.

The gum is the lower-risk option for those moments if you want something to take the edge off. What do you want to do about restarting?

Reply 4 of 9 · ID VHE9 (Sheet tab "3 KM7-P", rows marked 4 · VHE9)

She's right that how much and how often you use matters. But "a couple cigarettes is safer than vaping all day" isn't a comparison we can confidently make, especially without knowing your actual exposure.

Cigarettes add the harms of burning tobacco, including carbon monoxide and cancer-causing chemicals. Even light or occasional smoking carries health risks, particularly for your heart and blood vessels. Vaping isn't harmless, but switching to cigarettes isn't a reliable way to reduce harm.

I get why the idea appeals: you want something at parties without being attached to a vape all week. Nicotine gum or a lozenge is a much safer fallback than either smoking or vaping. They can maintain nicotine dependence temporarily, but they deliver nicotine more slowly, without smoke or vape aerosol, and can be tapered.

For your next attempt, skipping alcohol for a few outings and asking friends not to offer you their vapes could make a real difference. This weekend showed where the plan needed backup, not that you're bad at quitting.

Reply 5 of 9 · ID FEJW (Sheet tab "3 KM7-P", rows marked 5 · FEJW)

It sounds like a logical trade-off, doing something less often must be better than doing something all day, right? But medically speaking, she's incorrect.

The danger with cigarettes isn't just the nicotine, it's the combustion. When you light tobacco on fire, you are inhaling carbon monoxide, tar, and thousands of toxic chemicals that aren't present in vapes. Public health experts are very clear on this: there is no safe level of cigarette smoking. Even intermittent "social smoking" at parties causes immediate damage to your

blood vessels and significantly raises your risk of cardiovascular disease.

Plus, you already know you have a nicotine dependence. If you introduce cigarettes, your brain isn't going to politely keep them confined to party weekends. "Just a few at parties" is exactly how many daily smokers start, and you'd be risking a much more dangerous habit.

Trading a vape for combustible cigarettes is definitely going backward. You started this because you hated feeling controlled by a substance and didn't want to set a bad example for your little brother. Neither of those things gets solved by picking up smoking. Where does your head go when you think about just throwing away the disposable you bought this weekend?

Reply 6 of 9 · ID YLCE (Sheet tab "3 KM7-P", rows marked 6 · YLCE)

Your friend isn't right about that. A couple of cigarettes isn't a lighter version of vaping all day, burned tobacco sits at the more harmful end of the spectrum because of the combustion itself, not just the nicotine. "Only at parties" also tends to spread, which is how a lot of people end up smoking more than they planned.

The gum is still the lower-risk thing to have on you for those moments, used the way the label says. What's your gut saying about just restarting the quit instead of adding cigarettes in?

Reply 7 of 9 · ID K7TW (Sheet tab "3 KM7-P", rows marked 7 · K7TW)

I get the logic, doing something less often seems like it should be less harmful. But scientifically, she's off base.

The main issue is combustion. Vapes heat liquid, but cigarettes burn tobacco. That burning process creates tar, carbon monoxide, and dozens of known cancer-causing chemicals that vapes don't have. Even smoking just a few cigarettes introduces those heavy-hitting toxins into your lungs and does immediate damage to your blood vessels. There's really no "safe" level of smoking.

Plus, there's the addiction side. Because your brain is already dependent on nicotine from vaping, smoking "just at parties" rarely stays just at parties. It's incredibly common for people who try this to end up either smoking all week or doing both (smoking and vaping), which is the worst possible outcome for your health.

Basically, trading a vape for cigarettes is trading one problem for a much more dangerous one, while keeping the exact same nicotine addiction alive. It's a trap. How are you feeling about your vape right now, are you wanting to throw it out, or are you on the fence?

Reply 8 of 9 · ID JECM (Sheet tab "3 KM7-P", rows marked 8 · JECM)

It's easy to see why your friend thinks that, doing something less often sounds like it should be less harmful. But with combustible cigarettes, the math just doesn't work out that way.

Here is the reality: burning tobacco releases thousands of toxic chemicals and tar, making traditional cigarettes the absolute most dangerous way to consume nicotine. Health experts are very clear that there is no safe level of cigarette smoking. Even just a few cigarettes at a party can immediately damage your blood vessels and increase your risk for heart disease.

Plus, combustible cigarettes are engineered to deliver nicotine to your brain incredibly fast, which means "just at parties" has a very high chance of turning into a regular smoking habit.

It is completely normal to look for loopholes or compromises when quitting gets frustrating, your brain is just trying to find a way to get the nicotine it's craving. But trading a vape for cigarettes is a trap, not a downgrade. You've already proven you can go three days without vaping. Do you want to try throwing out the disposable you bought and giving it another go?

Reply 9 of 9 · ID UVL9 (Sheet tab "3 KM7-P", rows marked 9 · UVL9)

She's right about one piece: how much and how often you use matters. A couple of cigarettes occasionally and vaping all day are different exposures. But that doesn't establish that the cigarettes are safer overall, or make them harmless.

Cigarettes add the hazards of burning tobacco, including carbon monoxide and cancer-causing chemicals. Even light or occasional smoking carries health risks, particularly for your heart and blood vessels. Vaping isn't harmless either, and its long-term risks are less fully understood. There isn't a reliable conversion that lets us say "two cigarettes equals this much vaping."

So I should qualify my earlier answer: I can't confidently rank those exact patterns. What I can say is that starting cigarettes isn't a good harm-reduction strategy, especially when drinking already makes it easy for nicotine use to become automatic.

You also don't have to choose between smoking at parties and vaping all week. Nicotine gum or lozenges are much lower-risk than either, and a pharmacist can help you use them effectively for cravings. For your next attempt, temporarily skipping alcohol or staying off the vaping porch would address the trigger that caught you, not test your willpower harder.

That weekend doesn't erase the nearly two weeks you went without vaping. It gives you a specific part of the plan to change.

End of packet. Go to the next tab on your Start here list.